

KF49 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

We may now be ready to enter into stillness using the **Sunlight Meditation** without blending it with other meditation practices. Assume a meditation posture. Sit upright and straighten your neck by dropping your chin a little. Gently close your eyes. Begin with two minutes of **Alternate Nostril Breathing**. (*Pause for 2 minutes*)

Now, let go of **Alternate Nostril Breathing**. Focus on your breath and your forehead. If your mind wanders off into images or words, say to yourself, “Release thoughts,” and then draw your focus away from mental activity.¹ Return to stillness, and with your eyelids closed, gently turn your eyes upward as if you were looking at something close to your forehead. Breathe. (*Pause for 30 seconds*)

When you are ready, imagine that the light of the sun or a lamp is shining onto your forehead and into your eyes. If you wish to pace your breathing, inhale and exhale for the same amount of time. For example, you might inhale for six counts and pause for three counts, and then exhale for six counts and pause for three counts. When you are comfortable with the rhythm of your breathing, you can let go of counting. If your mind wanders, say to yourself, “Release thoughts,” and then gently draw your attention back to the light. Continue for two minutes while you rest in the stillness and gaze into the light. (*Pause for 2 minutes*)

Pause. Take a deep breath and gently open your eyes. Stretch and re-engage with the meeting.

Our hymn for the final month of the KF training cycle is *Be Thou My Vision*. This hymn was written in the 6th century by an Irish Christian poet, Dallan Forgaill.

Be Thou my Vision, O Lord of my heart;
Naught be all else to me, save that Thou art;
Thou my best Thought, by day or by night,
Waking or sleeping, Thy presence my Light.²

Take a deep breath.

(*If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?”*)

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION**0:21 TOOLBOX**

KF Confession 11 helps us build new foundations:

We take responsibility for any damage that we have done.

1. We first make efforts to restore the damage that we have done.

We can now tell the Lord that we are ready to take responsibility for the damage that we have done to our minds, our bodies, and our spirits. We begin with self-care and the hard work of redirecting our own lives toward habitual orientation. Once that process is in motion, we turn our attention to our relationships. We examine our behavior and our choices by asking ourselves, “Would I treat a stranger the way I have treated this person?” Our answer to that question may help us determine whether we have abused that person. We can then begin the essential work of changing our behavior, which will in turn initiate the rewarding process of healing our relationships. As I have mentioned before, simple good manners and consistent courtesy go a long way toward restoring damage that we have done. Once our close relationships have begun to move toward orientation, we can make efforts to restore damage in our wider community. If we have stolen from our community, we can take steps to repair the damage by offering karis gifts.

2. We are invited to restore damage wherever we meet it.

All of us have been damaged by other people. Now, we need to step into the adventure of healing that damage. We can either feel cheated, judge our situation as unfair and live in retaliation, or we can choose to reframe our story in the light of the Believe It Path and respond to God’s invitation to restore harmony by co-laboring with Him to heal the damage that has been done to us.

If our community has been damaged by others, we may be ready to take up the mission to overcome the injury with active goodness. We can do this in our jobs and through volunteer work, or simply by spreading goodwill wherever we go and in whatever situation we find ourselves. We can learn to smile as a habit. A smile is a gift.

3. We help to restore the damaged Creation.

The Creation encompasses everything from the cells in your body to the planets in the universe. The Creation is you and everything around you. We have begun to see how much we can influence both our own healing and the healing of others. We might think that healing ourselves and others is our only concern, but actually people are just a part of the Creation. The whole Creation, both animate and inanimate, is designed to reveal the glory of God. If, however, we damage that glorious Creation by our egocentric choices and steal from the lives of future generations, how will those generations experience God’s marvelous gifts and His beautiful goodness? The truth is that each one of us is part of the ecosystem of the entire Creation, so if the Creation is not functioning well, all of us are damaged.

We already have some idea of the damaging effects of misorientation. Through misorientation, we pollute and burden our lives and are, therefore, unable to fulfill the glory of God. We then compound the damage by polluting and burdening our environment. When we are misoriented, we live in an *ego*-system of craving and selfishness rather than in an *eco*-system of flow and cooperation. We then make up virtue stories about our actions and choices. In reality, each one of us is part of the ecosystem

of the whole Creation. By using our mindfulness training, we can observe how we treat the Creation, and just as we are beginning to clean up our own lives, we can, little by little, start helping to clean up our world.

We can learn to use less, reuse what we have, and recycle what we don't use. When we are tempted to litter or to leave a location less oriented than when we found it, we can respond mindfully and honor our ecosystem by making a small effort to tidy up. When you clean up your ecosystem, you clean up your soul. You might pick up a piece of litter and put it in the trash. That's a humble thing to do, but through this humble action you invite the karis of God into your life. Learn how you might help clean up the earth. Just as you would start to clean up your own life by taking one small step, choose one small action that will help restore the Creation, and then turn that action into a mindful practice. Perhaps it is your mission to be involved politically or in a business. You might be called to prevent cruelty to other creatures or to help clean up our water, food, and air. It's all spiritual work if done in partnership with God and through the True Self.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Creator, show me a small step that will help heal Your Creation. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?")

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

We might make KF Confession 11 one of our goals for this year:

We take responsibility for any damage that we have done.

Let's look at **Romans 8:16-23**. This is my translation, with a little paraphrase for clarity.

¹⁶The Spirit Himself is a witness with our spirit that we are the children of God. ¹⁷If children, we are heirs—heirs indeed of God! And not only that, but fellow-heirs with Christ, so we suffer with Him and jointly glorify Him, revealing His nature through our suffering. ¹⁸And with that understanding, I consider that whatever suffering there may be at this present moment is not even worth evaluating compared to the glory that God intends to reveal in us. ¹⁹We are creatures living in a material world, and that material world fully expects, and even eagerly anticipates, the revelation of the sons of God. ²⁰For the Creation was put on hold, not by choice, but by the one who subjected it, in the hope ²¹that the Creation itself will also be set free from slavery to deterioration and released into the liberty of the real glory of the children of God. ²²For we know that up to this time, we, with the whole Creation, groan and suffer as if in the pains of childbirth—²³not just as sufferers, but rather as those who, groaning within themselves as in the labor of birth, produce the firstfruits of the Spirit. We wait patiently and purposefully to be made sons, when our whole person will be ransomed and unified.

Take a deep breath.

In this passage, Paul teaches us that the whole point of our suffering in this life is to reveal our glory as heirs of God together with our Lord Jesus. When we choose to productively endure suffering, God can reveal through us the character of Jesus and the glory of our True Self. Together with the rest of Creation, we are suffering from the natural pain of birth as we move into the position of power and authority prepared for the sons and heirs of God. We are being ushered into a new state of being that is free from constant deterioration and misorientation. Every aspect of the Creation eagerly anticipates our coming and the revelation of our glory. When we become the people God intended us to be, the whole Creation will be liberated with us.

We and this material world labor together in the real hope that one day everything about us will be ransomed and made whole. Paul teaches that the Creation, with its material limitations, is actually supporting us in this process. By cooperating with the real limitations, cycles, and design of the Creation, we make use of the support that the Creation offers rather than struggling against that support. We waste so much energy fighting our birth because in our misorientation we hate any process that we cannot control. We want to live our lives as immature womb-children, so we refuse to learn to trust God and are unwilling to submit to His training. We have already decided how life should be and who we want to be, and we are averse to going into the not-knowing where we might experience some suffering. Right now, we are still in the process of birth. We do not yet see what we can become, but we have hope—just as God has hope—that if we participate in this process, we will all get to find out who we were meant to be.

Think of the Creation, which includes your own body and personality, as an ally, a friend who supports you in your birth. The limitations and seeming oppositions of the Creation are actually helping to move you toward your destiny—the destiny of becoming a son of God with all the rights of a son’s inheritance. Yes, this process is difficult, just as childbirth is difficult, but the oriented outcome is the regeneration of an independent, glorious, and powerful creature—YOU! You are the son who has chosen this training and is preparing for the delights and responsibilities of the glorious authority that belongs to the heirs of God.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Father, train me to enter into my inheritance with joy. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?”)

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some purified water and prepare to take some notes. Assume a meditation posture, and breathe.
(Pause for 10 seconds)

Here is our integration focus: *Consider entering into the delights and responsibilities of your inheritance. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

(Choose from each section a few sentences that are meaningful to you)

Feelings

As you consider entering into the delights and responsibilities of your inheritance, how does it feel? (Pause)
Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can often be

uncomfortable. *(Pause)* Recognize with compassion whatever you are experiencing, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Allow your experience to rest in your awareness. Step back and observe whatever you may be experiencing as you *consider entering into your inheritance*. *(Pause)* Feelings and passing thoughts are not right or wrong; they just are. Give yourself permission now to explore them without judgment, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Bring your attention to your body and notice what it is doing when you *consider entering into your inheritance*. What sensations are there? *(Pause)* Your body is always talking to you. You may not understand its language right now, but you can observe. For example, you might recognize what joy or despair feels like in your body. *(Pause)* If your sensations are too uncomfortable, you can take control and direct your attention to an area of the body that is not reacting. The sense of control may give you the confidence to return and observe the uncomfortable sensations. Breathe *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider entering into the delights and responsibilities of your inheritance*. Do you feel comfortable or uncomfortable with this idea, or perhaps confused or dismayed? Just observe. *(Pause)* Do you judge delight or responsibility as good or evil? Do you feel euphoria or fear? *(Pause)* When you think about this inheritance, what limitations or lack of limitations do you imagine? *(Pause)* Observe your responses as just information, and breathe with a long exhaling breath or the Dragon Breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

As you breathe, repeat the word *Welcome*. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

(Pause for 8 seconds or one long breath after each statement)

- Welcome this opportunity to explore the hope of your inheritance in Christ.
- Welcome the gentle Holy Spirit, who desires to train you for that inheritance.
- Welcome your present reality—where you are today and what your potential might be.
- Welcome what you are learning about yourself. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Now, as you breathe, you might use the following statements as a confession to the Lord and turn away from the Idol Self. On the exhale, let go.³

(Pause for 5 seconds after each statement)

- As I am trained for my inheritance, I let go of the craving for power and control.
- As I am trained for my inheritance, I let go of the craving for esteem and affection.
- As I am trained for my inheritance, I let go of the craving for security and superiority.
- As I am trained for my inheritance, I let go of the craving for perfection. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?")

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank You for inviting us to train together to receive our inheritance. Hold us in the power of this new understanding as You guide us to our real glory and to all that You intended us to be. Help us co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to further our connection with our true glory, with our mission, with the Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?")

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

The KF training cycle begins again in March. Admin requests that all current KF members register now on the website for the next KF cycle. If you know people who have graduated from the book study within the last year and have either not joined or dropped out of the Fellowships, you might wish to invite them to register for KF again. Simply let them know, as a courtesy and a gift, that the new cycle is due to begin. If they are interested in KF training, you might help them register on the website.

¹ "Let go, relax, and know that I am God" (Psalm 46:10).

² www.youtube.com/watch?v=ihJAJA4ibEs.

³ www.camillecaldwell.com/WelcomePrayer.html. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.